

# **Violent Extremism and Artificial Intelligence: A Double-Edged Sword in the Context of ASEAN**

Wan Rosalili Wan Rosli

Digital integration and the emergence of new technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI) are providing new tools for insurgents to use in spreading their propaganda through violent extremism. The Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) has come to represent a conduit for insurgents in planning and carrying out their extreme agendas. This article provides a deeper understanding of the double-edged sword effect of AI in relation to violent extremism in the ASEAN context. It reveals that, even though AI has been very important in countering violent extremism, it has simultaneously facilitated terrorists in spreading their propaganda in more innovative and covert ways. The legal framework governing AI is still in its infancy and challenges such as the double-edged sword effect in the use of the technology require specific guidelines or legislation for use in effective governance.

## **Biography**

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## Introduction

Violent extremism and radicalism are not a new phenomenon. They entail diverse beliefs without a specific definition and are not exclusive to any religion, nationality or system of belief (UNDP, 2016). Violent extremism is a broader term than terrorism but encompasses manifestations of terrorism, including ideologically motivated violence (UNODC, 2018). The US defines violent extremism as encouraging, condoning, justifying or supporting the commission of a violent act to achieve political, ideological, religious, social or economic goals (FBI, 2021). The UK Home Office (2023) defines it as vocal and active opposition to fundamental values, which include the rule of law, liberty and mutual respect towards different beliefs and faiths.

Counterterrorism started to evolve with the 9/11 War on Terror, which has had a strong focus on coercive measures, including hard military action, increasing policy powers and expanding intelligence services (CCE, 2023). However, the approach has shifted to become more non-coercive, including the formulation of strategies to prevent individuals from supporting terrorism (ibid.). The United Nations contends that the key elements to countering violent extremism (CVE) involve the use of non-coercive means to drive individuals or groups from using violence and to mitigate recruitment, support, facilitation or engagement (UNODC, n.d.). Neuman (2004) highlighted that CVE strategies involved a non-exhaustive list of activities by governmental and non-governmental entities in the fight to combat radicalisation, such as counter-messaging exercises through social media channels, community engagements, advisory council discussions, capacity-building, women and youth empowerment, and education and training of stakeholders.

In recent years, violent extremism has shifted from an approach of holding specific territories in specific jurisdictions to real-time communications on social media platforms, where those involved seek to spread their ideologies and propaganda.

## Comprehensive Analysis of AI-Enhanced Defense Systems in Cyberspace

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Accepted and Published: Dec 2023  
Abstract: The proliferation of cyber threats necessitates innovative defense mechanisms, and this paper presents a comprehensive review and analysis of AI-enabled approaches in cyberspace security. It investigates the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) algorithms, machine learning, and deep learning techniques into cybersecurity frameworks to counteract evolving threats. The study assesses the efficacy of AI in threat detection, anomaly identification, and predictive analysis within diverse cyber environments. Additionally, it scrutinizes the limitations and challenges associated with AI-driven defense strategies, emphasizing the ethical implications, adversarial attacks, and the need for interpretability and transparency in AI models. This research aims to provide a critical evaluation of the current landscape of AI-based defense mechanisms while highlighting their potential in fortifying cyber resilience and addressing emerging cyber threats.  
Key words: threats, defence, AI-driven, cybersecurity  
Introduction: In the contemporary digital landscape, the relentless surge in cyber threats poses an ever-growing challenge to the security of information systems and networks. The escalating sophistication and diversity of these threats demand a paradigm shift in defensive strategies. This paper embarks on

nda. The internet has no border control or checks and the lure of anonymity has changed the characteristics of violent extremism (Jacobsen, 2022; Khodzhanovna, 2023). Terrorist organisations see the internet as a safe way to recruit individuals and disseminate their ideology, especially through social media platforms such as Facebook, Twitter, YouTube and Instagram (Broeders et al., 2023).

Meanwhile, emerging technology such as artificial intelligence (AI) has contributed to the evolution of violent extremism. This article analyses the role of emerging technologies such as AI in facilitating the commission of acts of terror.

### **What is violent extremism?**

Violent extremism has been a major issue in countries' policies and development programmes in the past few decades. The term was coined to shift the focus away from an over-militarised approach after 9/11 and to enable a more moderate approach in countering and preventing extremism (Saraiva and Erfe, 2023). The United Nations Plan of Action to Prevent Violent Extremism 2015 aims to develop resilience in sections of communities that are prone to violent extremism (UNOCT, 2015).

Although the concept is recognised across international communities, a uniform definition has never been agreed upon. As a result, the concept is easily manipulated, which poses a critical challenge to authorities and can sometimes also lead to the over-securitisation of specific sectors to further legitimise the war against terror (Stephens et al., 2021). The United Nations Special Rapporteur on the protection of human rights concluded that 'the lack of semantic and conceptual clarity that surrounds violent extremism remains an obstacle to any in-depth examination of the impact of strategies and policies to counter violent extremism on human rights as well as on their effectiveness in reducing the threat of terrorism' (Emmerson, 2016: para. 55).

Violent extremism includes elements of radicalisation, which is a process of embracing religious, political and social ideation that causes violent acts between members or groups (Doosje and van Eerten, 2017; Borum, 2023). Alcalá et al. (2017) contend that the promotion and adoption of extremist beliefs to advance violence leads to violent radicalisation, which has a critical effect on religion and society. Recent research has also highlighted that there are many aspects to extremist behaviour, emerging from cultural, educational and psychological factors. Interestingly, Stankov et al. (2018) contend that the ideology of extremism and radicalisation depends on mindsets, and extremist behaviours can be found in